

Md. Juwel Ahmed Sarker

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

School Finance; Economics of Education; Teacher Labor Markets; Higher Education and Education–Employment Linkages; Applications of Machine Learning to Education Policy.

EDUCATION

Expected 2027 **Ph.D. in Education Policy, University of Arkansas**

Dissertation: *“Making School Dollars Meaningful: Consolidation, Efficiency, and the Economics of School Finance”*

Committee: Josh B. McGee (Chair), Harry Patrinos, Robert Maranto

2018 M.Econ, Development Economics, Dhaka School of Economics

2012 M.S.S., Development Studies, University of Dhaka

2011 B.S.S. (Honors), Development Studies, University of Dhaka

JOB MARKET PAPER

“When Small Districts Disappear: Fiscal Consequences of Consolidation in Arkansas,” with Josh B. McGee. *[EDRE Working Paper 2026-NN — add number and link once assigned]*, University of Arkansas.

Presented at AEFPP 51st Annual Conference, Chicago, 2026; forthcoming at SREE 2026 and the ABFM 38th Annual Research Conference, Washington, DC, September 2026.

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Academic Appointments

2023–Present Graduate Assistant, University of Arkansas

2019–Present Assistant Professor (on leave), Hajee Mohammad Danesh Science and Technology University, Dinajpur, Bangladesh

2021–23 Chairman, Department of Development Studies, Hajee Mohammad Danesh Science and Technology University

2022–23 Assistant Proctor, Hajee Mohammad Danesh Science and Technology University

2021–22 Assistant Hall Superintendent, Hajee Mohammad Danesh Science and Technology University

Professional Experience

2015–2019 Program Officer, Skills for Employment Investment Program (SEIP), Palli Karma-Sahayak Foundation

2013–2015 Research Associate, Microcredit Regulatory Authority

2015 Junior Consultant, National Land Zoning Project, Ministry of Land, Bangladesh

Research Assistantships

2012 Field Research Assistant, Bangladesh Enterprise Institute (BEI), “Local Government Audit and Accountability Systems” Project

- 2012 Intern, UNDP, Dhaka, Bangladesh, in the Poverty Environment and Climate Mainstreaming Project (PECM)
- 2011 Field Research Assistant, Department of Development Studies, University of Dhaka, in the “Dynamics of Urban Poverty” project (under Prof. M. Abu Eusuf)
- 2009–2011 Research Assistant, Institute for Research and Development (IRD), Dhaka

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

- 2026 **Sarker, M. J. A.**, Maranto, R., Haque, A., & Sagar, M. S. U. (2026). Social media impacts on Bangladeshi college students. *Discover Psychology*.
- 2025 **Sarker, M. J. A.**, Hasan, M., Kabir, A., & Haque, A. (2025). Leveraging artificial intelligence to assess the impact of COVID-19 on the teacher-student relationship in higher education. *PLOS ONE*, 20(3), e0317567.
- 2022 Hossain, M. T., Islam, M. A., Jahan, N., Nahar, M. T., **Sarker, M. J. A.**, Rahman, M. M., ... & Islam, M. N. (2022). Mental health status of teachers during the second wave of the COVID-19 pandemic: a web-based study in Bangladesh. *Frontiers in Psychiatry*, 13, 938230.
- Hossain, M. T., Ahammed, B., Jahan, N., Islam, M. A., Rahman, M. M., Khan, B., **Sarker, M. J. A.**, ... & Islam, M. N. (2022). Prevalence and predictors of pornography exposure during the third wave of the COVID-19 pandemic: A web-based cross-sectional study on students in Bangladesh. *Frontiers in Public Health*, 10, 1046813.

Book Chapters

- 2020 **Sarker, M. J. A.** (2020). The readymade garment sector: Vulnerabilities and resilience. In R. A. M. Titumir, N. Georgeou, & A. Chowdhury (Eds.), *COVID-19 and Bangladesh: Response, Rights, and Reliance* (pp. 75–81). University Publication Limited.

Under Review

- Sarker, M. J. A.**, Hasan, M., Kabir, A., Haque, A., & Hamja, A. (under review). A data-driven analysis of the education-employment linkage with explainable artificial intelligence. *Telematics and Informatics Report*.

MANUSCRIPTS IN PREPARATION

- Sarker, M. J. A., & McGee, J. B. (n.d.). “*Merging for Efficiency? Causal Evidence from Arkansas School District Consolidation.*”
Presented under an earlier working title (“Assessing Relative Educational Efficiency of Arkansas School Districts Using a Modified Simar-Wilson Two-Stage DEA”) at AEFPP 50th Annual Conference, Washington, DC, 2025, and (as “Measuring Efficiency of School Districts in Arkansas: A Data-Driven Approach”) at SREE 2025.
- Sarker, M. J. A., McGee, J. B., & Maranto, R. (n.d.). “*The Leadership Multiplier: How Leadership Shapes the Meaning of School Dollars.*”
(Manuscript drafted).
- Sarker, M. J. A., Sagar, M. S. U., Tabassum, A., & Islam, T. (n.d.). “*Cannot Read a Word: Predictors of Non-Reading and the Literacy Gap in Rural Bangladesh.*”
(Manuscript drafted).

McGee, J. B., Sarker, M. J. A., Zamarro, G., & Camp, A. (n.d.). *"If at First You Don't Succeed: The Impact of Failing the First Attempt on a Teacher Licensure Exam on Licensure, Employment, and Value-Added."*

(Manuscript drafted and Presented under evolving working titles at AEF 49th Annual Conference, Baltimore, MD, March; SREE 2024; and the APPAM Fall Research Conference, National Harbor, MD, November).

Sarker, M. J. A., Sagar, M. S. U., Tofayel, A. H., Nahid, F., & Jahan, S. (n.d.). *"Stuck on Mobile: Device Access and the Gender Digital Skills Gap."*

(Manuscript drafted).

Wolf, P., Shakil, D., Patrinos, H., Daniels, D., Wilson, T., Helal, A. M., & Sarker, M. J. A. (n.d.). *"The Impact of Private School Choice on Student Attainment around the Globe: A Meta-Analysis & Returns to Education Study."*

Data analysis underway.

Helal, A. M., Wai, J., Sarker, M. J. A., & Rieske, A. (n.d.). *"The Returns to Gifted Education: A Meta-Analysis of Academic and Long-Term Outcomes Across Research Designs."* (Initial draft complete).

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

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| 2026 | <p>Sarker, M. J. A., & McGee, J. B. (2026, September). <i>When small districts disappear: The fiscal consequences of consolidation in Arkansas</i> [Paper presentation]. SREE 2026 Conference. (forthcoming, September 23–26)</p> <p>Sarker, M. J. A., & McGee, J. B. (2026, September). <i>When small districts disappear: The fiscal consequences of consolidation in Arkansas</i> [Paper presentation]. ABFM 38th Annual Research Conference, Washington, DC. (forthcoming, September 24–26)</p> <p>Sarker, M. J. A., & McGee, J. B. (2026). <i>When small districts disappear: Fiscal consequences of consolidation in Arkansas</i> [Paper presentation]. AEF 51st Annual Conference, Chicago, IL.</p> |
| 2025 | <p>Sarker, M. J. A., & McGee, J. B. (2025, September). <i>Measuring efficiency of school districts in Arkansas: A data-driven approach</i> [Paper presentation]. SREE 2025 Conference.</p> <p>Sarker, M. J. A., & McGee, J. B. (2025). <i>Assessing relative educational efficiency of Arkansas school districts using a modified Simar-Wilson two-stage Data Envelopment Analysis (DEA)</i> [Paper presentation]. AEF 50th Annual Conference, Washington, DC.</p> <p>Sarker, M. J. A., & Robert, M. (2025). <i>Will social media contagion harm teens in non-Western societies? Experience of Bangladesh</i> [Poster presentation]. AEF 50th Annual Conference, Washington, DC.</p> |
| 2024 | <p>McGee, J. B., Sarker, M. J. A., Zamarro, G., & Camp, A. (2024, November). <i>If at first you don't succeed: The impact of failing the first attempt on a teacher licensure exam on licensure, employment, and value-added</i> [Paper presentation]. APPAM Fall Research Conference, National Harbor, MD.</p> <p>McGee, J. B., Sarker, M. J. A., Zamarro, G., & Camp, A. (2024, September). <i>Assessing the impact of teacher licensure exam scores on licensure, employment as teacher, and teaching effectiveness</i> [Paper presentation]. SREE 2024 Conference.</p> |

McGee, J. B., Sarker, M. J. A., Zamarro, G., & Camp, A. (2024, March). *Assessing the relationship between teacher licensure exam scores and classroom effectiveness* [Paper presentation]. AEFP 49th Annual Conference, Baltimore, MD.

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

2026–2027	School Finance Fellow, EdFund
2023–Present	Doctoral Academy Fellow, University of Arkansas
2022	Best Research Paper Presenter (Social Science Faculties), Institute for Research and Training (IRT), Hajee Mohammad Danesh Science and Technology University
2012	Governor Scholarship, Bangladesh Bank
2011	Development Studies Scholarship, University of Dhaka
2009–10	Genius Scholarship, Centre for Zakat Management (CZM), Dhaka

GRANTS AND FUNDED PROJECTS

2025	Research Travel Grant, Graduate-Professional Student Congress (GPSC), University of Arkansas (\$700).
2023	Principal Investigator, “ <i>Digital Bangladesh and Youth Employment: How Can Digital Competence Enhance Employability of Tertiary Graduates in Bangladesh?</i> ” University Grant Commission, Bangladesh (\$2,000).
2022–23	Principal Investigator, “ <i>Connecting Life: Predicting and Preventing Suicide among University Students through Machine Learning Methods,</i> ” Institute of Research and Training (\$1,400).
	Principal Investigator, “ <i>What Causes Unemployment among Educated Youths in Bangladesh? Demystifying the Psycho-Social and Socio-Economic Narratives,</i> ” Institute of Research and Training (\$1,000).
2021–22	Evaluation Expert, <i>Impact Evaluation of e-Learning Pilot Project</i> , UNDP Bangladesh (\$3,000).
2021	Principal Investigator, “ <i>Linking Education to Employment in Bangladesh: Where to Focus?</i> ” Social Science Research Council, Ministry of Planning, Bangladesh (\$2,000).
2020–21	Principal Investigator, “ <i>Operational Efficiency of and Financial Inclusion in the Microfinance Sector in Bangladesh: A Panel Analysis,</i> ” Institute of Research and Training, HSTU (\$1,000).
2019–20	Principal Investigator, “ <i>Perception and Practice of Freedom and Independence among Working Women in Bangladesh,</i> ” Institute of Research and Training, HSTU (\$900).

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Department of Education Reform, University of Arkansas

2024	Teaching Assistant, EDRE 61003: Quantitative Analytical Techniques for Education Policy, Fall 2024
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Hajee Mohammad Danesh Science and Technology University, Dinajpur, Bangladesh

2023	DEV 125: Technological Revolutions and Development, Spring 2023
	DEV 126: Computing and Data Analysis Skills for Development (Lab), Spring 2023

	DEV 225: NGOs and Development Management, Spring 2023
	DEV 325: Education, Health, Labour, and Human Development, Spring 2023
	ECN 251: Mathematical Economics, Spring 2023
	SOC 413: Social Policy and Planning, Spring 2023
2022	DEV 125: Technological Revolutions and Development, Spring 2022
	DEV 126: Computing and Data Analysis Skills for Development (Lab), Spring 2022
	DEV 215: Environment, Development and Sustainability, Spring 2022
	DEV 225: NGOs and Development Management, Spring 2022
	DEV 313: Poverty and Inequality: Concept, Measurement and Policy, Fall 2022
	DEV 317: Banking, Finance and Insurance, Fall 2022
	ECN 301: Development Economics, Fall 2021
2021	ECN 125: Macroeconomics, Fall 2021
	DEV 215: Environment, Development and Sustainability, Spring 2021
	ECN 129: Economics, Fall 2019
2019	ECN 125: Macroeconomics, Fall 2019
	ECN 307: History of Economic Thought, Fall 2019

Pedagogical Training

2022	Objective-Based Curriculum Development and Classroom Management, Hajee Mohammad Danesh Science and Technology University.
2018	Overseas Pedagogy Training for Bangladeshi TVET Trainers: Student-Centered Lesson Plan Development and Classroom Management, Institute of Technical Education – Education Services, Singapore (June 17–30).

SERVICE

Manuscript Reviewer

Humanities & Social Sciences Communications (Nature Portfolio), 2025 • Gifted Child Quarterly, 2025–2026 • PLOS ONE, 2022 • International Journal of School Choice, 2026

Professional Memberships

Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP) • Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM) • Society for Research on Educational Effectiveness (SREE) • Lifetime Registered Graduate, University of Dhaka

University Service

2025	Department Representative, Department of Education Reform, Graduate-Professional Student Congress (GPSC), University of Arkansas
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Departmental Leadership

2021–23	DevTalk — initiated an academia–industry collaboration through student fieldwork placements, internships, and a workshop series with visiting professionals, as Chairman, Department of Development Studies, Hajee Mohammad Danesh Science and Technology University
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2020 Led undergraduate curriculum development, Department of Development Studies, Hajee Mohammad Danesh Science and Technology University

Leadership Initiatives

2020–21 Founder, Bangladesh Open Learning Society (BOLS) — an online learning community of over 10,000 members who completed more than 70,000 hours of coursework and earned 4,500 course certificates (Coursera, edX) during the COVID-19 pandemic

Community Service

Backpacks of Hope, distribution of educational materials to disadvantaged children (2023) • General Secretary, Kabi Jasim Uddin Hall Debating Club, University of Dhaka • Team Lead, University of Dhaka Debate Team, National and International Debate Championships, incl. Quarterfinalist, 2nd OIC Intervarsity Debate Tournament (2012) • Blood Donor, Badhan, University of Dhaka

SKILLS

Causal Inference & Econometric Methods: Randomized Controlled Trials (RCT), Regression Discontinuity Design (RDD), Difference-in-Differences (DID), Instrumental Variables (IV)

Quantitative Methods: Hierarchical Linear Modeling (HLM), Structural Equation Modeling (SEM), Machine Learning / Explainable AI, Data Envelopment Analysis (DEA), Stochastic Frontier Analysis (SFA)

Survey Design & Field Data Collection: questionnaire design, enumerator training and supervision, baseline/endline survey implementation

Qualitative Research Methods: life history method, in-depth interviews (IDI), focus group discussions (FGD), key informant interviews (KII)

Statistical/Programming: Stata, R, Python

Other: MS Project

REFERENCES

Dr. Josh B. McGee (Dissertation Chair)

Associate Professor of Education Reform; 21st Century Endowed Chair in Accountability and Transparency; Faculty Affiliate, Office for Education Policy

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Dr. Harry Patrinos

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Dr. Robert Maranto

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